

Toner and Ink Cartridges

Cartridges are not only the most important part of a printer, they are also the only part that is maintained and handled by the user. We tell you how to squeeze the last drop out of your cartridges, and get crisp and sharp prints that won't burden your pocket.

■ Laser Printers

Generally, over 50 per cent of printing problems related to laser printers are resolved when the toner cartridge is cleaned. So, clean your toner cartridge regularly. Never touch the drum surface while handling toner cartridges since this could lead to oil spots and scratches which will be evident on your printouts. Also, the cartridge should be protected from sunlight so it's always stored in its original box.

At times, in certain HP printers, the screw in the cartridge cover becomes loose due to vibrations. This screw needs to be checked and tightened, if you see a horizontal white line in the centre of a printed page.

Another common problem is the black dots that appear on printouts. This is usually because of a nick on the drum, caused by a foreign object. If this has happened, there's no way you can get the cartridge repaired—you'll have to replace it. So make sure you are using dust-free paper. Also, keep the printer clean—

clean the outer surface regularly. Use a damp cloth to clean the accumulated debris and dust, whenever you are changing a cartridge. Pay special attention to the rubber rollers—never use alcoholic cleaners on these.

■ Inkjet Printers

If you are installing a new cartridge in your inkjet printer, keep it in the upright position for a few moments before fitting it in. This ensures that the ink will be at the nozzle when you are ready to use the printer. Also, store the cartridge in an upright position, in an airtight, rigid plastic container. Whenever you feel that your prints aren't as crisp as they should be, run the printer's head-cleaning utility. This is necessary especially if you are using your printer after a long time.

Using the Right Paper

The regular paper that you use for printing does fine for day-to-day print jobs. However, at times, you may want to print on special types of paper. Different types of paper are available for different printing needs.

■ Photo Paper

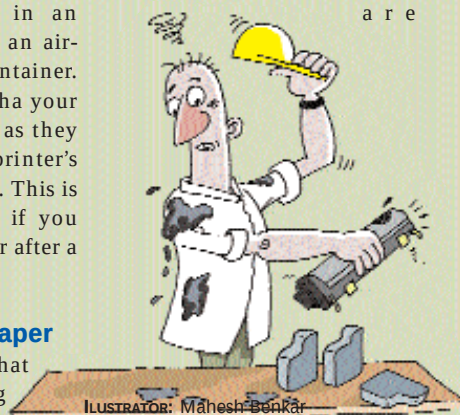
This is similar to the paper used by film developers, and is designed to produce high-quality images. They come in both, matte and glossy finish, and in standard photo sizes such as 4 X 6 inches. Use photo paper for studio quality photos.

■ Greeting cards

These papers are thicker, pre-folded, and smaller than regular paper. They come with matching envelopes. Printers typically come with bundled software, with several templates, for creating greeting cards. Use this paper to create personalised greeting cards that have a professional look.

■ Glossy paper

Glossy paper has a shiny, coated surface on one or both sides. This produces vibrant colours, but the prints are



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar

susceptible to fingerprints. Use glossy paper for brochures, flyers and report covers.

■ Transparencies

These are clear plastic sheets, and are used to create overhead-projector presentations. These can only be used with inkjet printers, as transparencies cannot tolerate the heat generated by laser printers.

■ Craft papers

Craft papers come in a huge

variety. For example, iron-on paper allows you to print and image and transfer it to a cloth. Banner papers, used to create banners, also come in this category. Other papers in this category are Vellum, parchment, printable fabric sheets, shrink-wrap plastic and so on.

■ Stickers and labels

Stickers and labels are available for mail, folders, diskettes, CDs and whatever else you can think of. You can use fonts, images and colours to customise them. Re-stickables allow for a lot of creative flexibility.

Remember to check your printer manual for compatibility, before using specialty papers. Otherwise, you may experience paper jams and such.

Maintenance

■ Clear paper jams

Carelessness while clearing a paper jam could lead to accumulation of toner dust, which could be hazardous to the health of your printer. If the paper jams before it reaches the Fuser roller—the roller that fuses the toner with the paper—the toner will just lie on the page, in the shape of the image being printed. Caution is necessary here, so that the toner doesn't fall into the printer while you're pulling out the paper. If it has not yet begun to come out of the printer, pull the paper towards the inside of the printer. If the paper had just begun to feed, and you